

Chapter 37 Part 1

Above the mountain ridges was lush green vegetation that covered the sky and blocked out the sun. Below the cloud peaks were layers of fog that could not disperse, shrouding the entire mountain and tinting the verdant green with a layer of white.

The mountain streams flowed with gurgling water, and occasionally the sounds of wild beasts calling could be heard.

Inside the house.

Qiu Zimin knelt in the proper sitting posture¹.

A middle-aged man dressed in a blue shirt² had brewed a pot of tea. Steam drifted throughout the room. After meticulously wiping his hands, he lowered his eyes and inquired again: "Have you discussed this matter with your husband?"

"Sir, you don't need to beat around the bush. If there's something you want to know, I'll tell you directly." Qiu Zimin lowered her voice: "You only need to say that she can serve as a sacrificial offering, and that once it's done, it will bring prosperity and good fortune to the Liang family. That would be sufficient."

"Madam Liang is truly heartless." The middle-aged man smiled: "But she cannot serve as a sacrificial offering."

Qiu Zimin frowned, "Why not?"

The middle-aged man calmly sipped his tea and said indifferently: "She has two types of fortune on her, one strong and one weak. If the weak one could become strong at this moment, perhaps there would be a need for changing her fortune. But now her luck is obviously too poor. Even if it were changed, it wouldn't benefit the Liang family at all. Moreover, changing fortune is all illusory and ethereal. The way of heaven has its cycles and its own cause and effect. How could it be changed through ritual practices?"

"But since you said it could be changed, then it can be changed." Qiu Zimin said with certainty.

Suddenly, from the clear sky came the desolate cry of a lone eagle, like dozens of airplanes thundering overhead all at once.

The sound was so loud it nearly deafened Liang Shi, and her entire head was buzzing.

The scene before her eyes kept retreating and blurring until everything became dark.

Then a strong light shone in, and Liang Shi suddenly opened her eyes.

It was already morning. Sunlight passed through the gaps in the curtains and refracted into the room, landing right on her pillow.

Liang Shi raised her hand to wipe her forehead. Cold sweat poured down, and even her palms were damp with heat.

Rather than calling it a dream, it was more like something the original body had personally experienced.

She was like an observer watching the young Liang Shi standing in the mountains, while also being able to hear the conversation between Qiu Zimin and the middle-aged man inside the house.

But it had come to an abrupt end.

However, she could confirm that the original body's room was indeed related to sacrifice.

Damn!

Couldn't they eliminate feudal superstition?

Feudal superstition kills people!

Liang Shi looked at her watch. It wasn't time for her alarm to go off yet. Taking advantage of the morning yang energy³, she opened the curtains and then opened the photo gallery, taking out that photograph, trying to discover more clues.

But the background of that photo was too dark, and the photography technology of the past wasn't very advanced either. The pixels were low. After looking at it for a long time, she couldn't make anything out. Later, when she went to wash up, she found it somewhat difficult to look directly at her own face.

By the end of washing her face, she had become somewhat irritated, and two words popped into her mind—bad luck.

Qiu Zimin should know that the original body wasn't her child, and she also harbored hatred toward the original body.

But such a small child—what hatred could she have generated with her?

Was it because of the original body's parents?

But who were the original body's parents? Did Qiu Zimin know?

If she knew, then why didn't she directly take revenge on the adults instead of taking it out on a child?

That meant Qiu Zimin couldn't afford to offend the adults of this family.

But if they were people Qiu Zimin couldn't afford to offend, why were they able to switch out the child?

It was also possible that Qiu Zimin was simply psychologically twisted, so she handed the original body over to Mrs. Qi and made the original body a sacrificial offering.

There were too many possibilities. Question after question tangled in Liang Shi's mind like a ball of yarn with no visible starting thread.

Thinking about it all early in the morning gave Liang Shi such a headache, but she still couldn't figure out anything. These things exceeded her scope of understanding.

After washing up, she slowly went downstairs, thinking that since it was still early today, she should have plenty of time to make breakfast. But when she came downstairs, Xu Qingzhu was already busy in the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu's cooking skills were limited—fried eggs, bread, and soy milk constituted their breakfast for two.

Breakfast was eaten in silence, with both harboring their own thoughts.

Xu Qingzhu had also seen that photograph, but she asked nothing and said nothing. The only thing similar between her and Liang Shi was that they both sported two huge dark circles under their eyes.

Both had spent a sleepless night.

¹ **Kneeling sitting posture (跪坐禮):** A traditional formal sitting position in East Asian cultures where one kneels and sits back on their heels, often used in formal or ceremonial contexts to show respect.

² **Blue shirt (青衫):** A traditional Chinese garment, often associated with scholars or Taoist practitioners in classical literature.

³ **Yang energy (陽氣):** In traditional Chinese philosophy, yang represents the active, masculine, light, and positive principle. Morning is considered a time when yang energy is strongest and most pure.